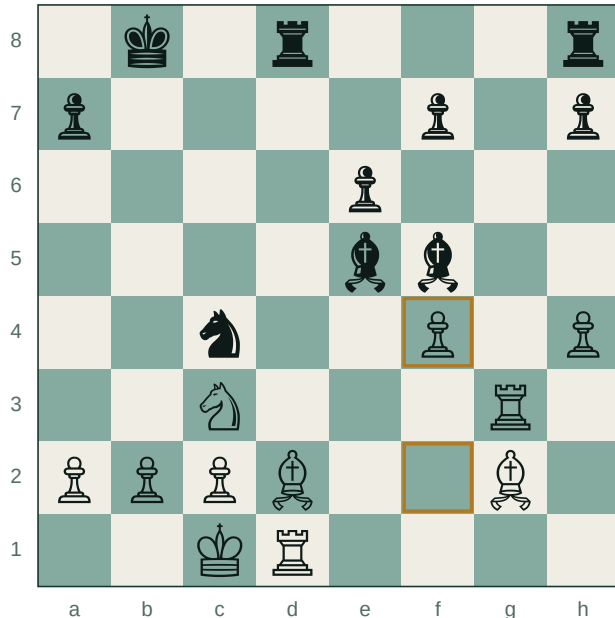


Capture the defender: Black, move 24

Capture the defender

Black to move



Previous move: 24.f4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

24...Rxd2 25. Rxd2 Bxf4

24...Rxd2 The rook captures the bishop on d2. From d2 it attacks rook on d1 and bishop on g2. Recorded reply: **25.Rxd2**.

25...Bxf4 The bishop captures the pawn on f4. From f4 it attacks rook on g3 and rook on d2.

At the end, nominal material is White 20 / Black 18 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by -1. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** -1: the balance goes from -1 to -2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on c1. Geometrically undefended: rook on g3. Check for tactical protection.